

CHESSBASE INDIA

A HERO'S WELCOME Vaishali with her family at Chennai airport, Apr. 19

RISING FROM THE ASHES

However, resilient as she may be, 2025 was Vaishali's toughest year and she nearly gave up hope of qualifying for the Candidates. "If you see my [Elo] rating, it dropped. Everything was going wrong," she says. At the Chennai Grandmasters, she scored just one out of a possible nine points. International Master (IM) and ChessBase India co-founder Sagar Shah, who covered the tournament, recalls Vaishali being outplayed in almost every game. Low on confidence and feeling a little lost, what helped was the support of family and chess friends. Vaishali recalled how GM Karthikeyan Murali told her to not let self-doubt cripple her. "He said my self-worth shouldn't be judged by one tournament," she told ChessBase India in an interview later. Her brother Pragg pushed her to play the FIDE Grand Swiss tournament, which she went on to win to qualify for the Candidates. "Even when I doubted myself, they kept believing in me," she says.

Losses, it is a common belief in the sporting world, teach you more than victories. Slumps are part and parcel of the game, but it's the way players deal with adversity that make them stand out. "If you overanalyse the rough period, it could be harmful," said Anand. "It's the best time to experiment, introspect, examine what you can change, take some risks." Or, as Vaishali puts it, "Every time I go low, I also peak."

Vaishali had a nervy moment at the 2026 Candidates when, in her own words, she started with "shaky, high-pressure games", leading to four consecutive draws followed by a loss. "I was scoring points by luck," she told FIDE in an interview after her win. By the time she scored her second win, courtesy a massive blunder by former world champion Tan Zhongyi, Vaishali had willed herself to focus on the quality of her play. A point up and just three rounds to go, she lost to Chinese GM Zhu Jiner. "Things had started to go wrong, but she kept her cool," says Shah, who observed Vaishali from close quarters. "That loss to Zhu would have been the end of the road for many...but she found a way to take it in her stride." Again, Vaishali had her team to thank for her holding steady. That team included GM Pranesh M., who was brought in to keep the mood light and help plan openings and play blitz games.



> **"Vaishali is very tenacious. Even when she has lost, she has never fully lost.... She turns around a lot of games from difficult positions"**
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> **VISWANATHAN ANAND**
> *Ex-World Champion; co-founder, WestBridge Anand Chess Academy*

THE COUNTDOWN BEGINS

Grandmaster Koneru Humpy was the first and last Indian woman to vie for the world champion's throne, back in 2011. Anand sees similarities in her and Vaishali—both are great students of the game with the acumen and nous for a long career. As Vaishali gets into what will be a period of intense preparation, Anand offers some valuable advice. "Though the occasion puts a lot of pressure on you, in the end, it's just chess," he said. "It's not some magical thing where you will do things different. It's about turning up and playing a good game. I will just tell her to be confident and bold."

On coach Ramesh falls the job of preparing Vaishali for the epic battle. But he isn't too worried about his "most hard-working" student. "There are people who want great things in every aspect of life without deserving any of it. Vaishali has made a lot of sacrifices to focus on chess. Her commitment to the game, discipline...they are all qualities that behove a great champion." ■